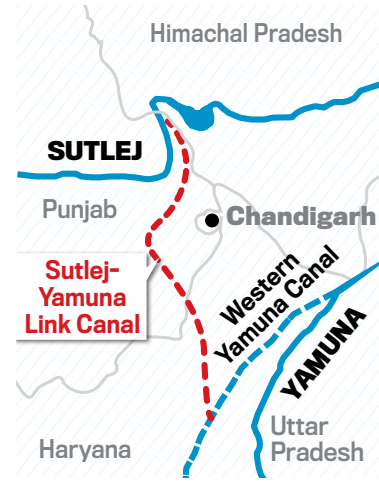


HARMEET SODHI



PUNJAB/ SYL CANAL

TROUBLE FOR MANN

doesn't have sufficient water to spare for the neighbouring state. Even as the top court posted the matter for further hearing in January 2024, its observations and directions triggered statewide protests in Punjab, with farmers' unions, social organisations and political parties up in arms.

Finding itself cornered, the Bhagwant Mann-led government 'sacked' advocate general Vinod Ghai, replacing him with senior advocate Gurminder Singh—the third appointment to the post since the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) came to power in Punjab in March last year. In an attempt to reclaim the narrative after being accused of compromising the state's interests in the Supreme Court, Mann even challenged his rivals—Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) state chief Sunil Jakhar, Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) supremo Sukhbir Singh Badal and the leader of the Opposition, Partap Singh Bajwa—for an open debate on issues concerning the state. To Mann's surprise, each of them gave their consent quite promptly. Since then, both the CM and his party's leadership have gone silent on the matter.

Even though AAP won a massive mandate last year, winning 92 of the 117 assembly seats, it has been struggling to strengthen its cadre across Punjab. Legacy issues, such as the contentious SYL canal, are only compounding its problems. At the root of this specific issue is the 1981 water-sharing agreement between Congress chief ministers Darbara Singh in Punjab and Bhajan Lal in Haryana—15 years after Haryana was carved out of Punjab in 1966. The agreement legitimised an executive order passed in March 1976—during the Emergency—that allocated 3.5 MAF (million acre feet) of Punjab's share of the waters of the Ravi and Beas rivers (of the Sutlej system) to Haryana. The 214-kilometre SYL canal, of which a 122-km stretch was to come up in Punjab and the remaining 92 km in Haryana, was conceived to operationalise this agreement.

Even as the acquisition of land went on in the two states through the 1980s, the project faced stiff